

Q Are there any natural ways to bring on labor?

Anecdotaly, there are various “natural” ways to induce labor. However, there is not enough scientific evidence to confirm that they are genuinely effective at starting birth. Still, as long as your pregnancy has been complication-free, you are full term, and you have no reason to believe your baby could become distressed, they can be worth a try. Tell your doctor if you intend to try any of these methods.

» **Meditation and hypnosis:** when you're stressed or anxious, your body releases adrenalin, which signals to your brain that now would not be a good time to give birth. In turn, this inhibits the release of oxytocin, the hormone that starts your labor. Meditation and hypnosis can help you relax, in turn removing the neurological barriers to oxytocin release.

» **Having sex:** it's said that the contractions of the uterus during an orgasm can act as a catalyst for bringing on labor contractions, while the intimacy of sex itself, and of being close to someone you love and trust, releases the hormone oxytocin. Furthermore, some say that the prostaglandins (chemical messengers) in semen can soften the cervix to trigger the start of labor. Don't have sex if your water has broken, though, since you are at increased risk of infection.

» **Nipple massage:** gently rubbing your nipples and rolling them between your thumb and forefinger can release oxytocin. The goal is to simulate the action of a baby sucking on your breast, so you'll need to be methodical if you are to use this approach. Just as a breast-feeding baby would feed from one breast for 20 minutes or so, and then the other, and every few hours, for the best effects you

need to do the same. It can take up to 72 hours to have the necessary effect on your body to induce labor—so you will need to be dedicated to the cause to make this worthwhile!

» **Acupuncture:** in this form of traditional Chinese medicine a qualified acupuncturist inserts tiny needles into your body along “meridians”—energy lines that interconnect to trigger certain effects throughout the physical body. Some women swear by acupuncture for induction of labor, but there is no rigorous scientific evidence that says it works. If you want to give it a try, aim to find a practitioner who is experienced in treating pregnant women, and talk to your doctor first.

» **Homeopathy:** there is no firm evidence that homeopathy works for inducing labor. If you want to try a homeopathic remedy, though, make sure you consult a registered homeopath with experience of treating pregnant women. You should always talk to your doctor first.

» **Spicy foods:** some curry and chili-pepper dishes stimulate your digestion and create “heat” in your body. Many women claim that the activity in the intestine and bowel has helped to bring on labor. There's no harm in giving it a try (aside, perhaps, from an increased risk of heartburn and indigestion!).

» **Fresh pineapple:** pineapple stimulates your digestion (this time because it contains a digestive enzyme called bromelain), which some claim can help stimulate the uterus to begin contracting. However, it takes a lot of pineapple to raise the levels of bromelain in your system for any effect—several whole pineapples—so you are probably more likely to end up with an upset stomach in the next 24 hours than delivering your baby.

» **Herbal remedies:** there are some herbs that are said to help bring on labor. These include black cohosh and evening primrose oil. Remember, though, never to use any herbal remedy without getting the go-ahead from your doctor, since it may have harmful effects on you or your baby.

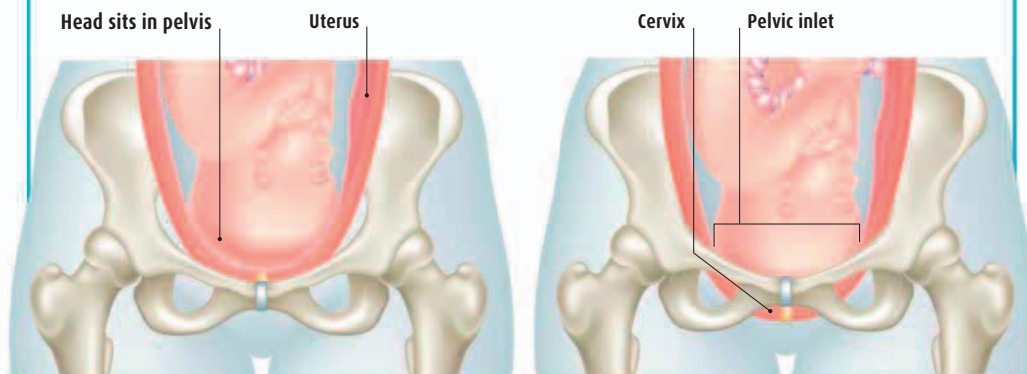
» **Raspberry leaf tea:** while evidence does suggest that raspberry leaf stimulates the action of the uterus, medically it is discouraged for the induction of labor because overstimulating the uterus can cause distress for the baby.

Q What does it mean for the baby's head to “engage”?

Known colloquially as “dropping,” a baby engages when the widest part of her head has descended into the cavity in your pelvic bones (the pelvic inlet).

Engagement isn't something that happens in a single moment, but over time—usually starting between 34 and 36 weeks pregnant. It can take several weeks for a baby slowly and methodically to move herself into position. Other times, the baby will wait until labor has actually begun, allowing your contractions to provide the push she needs finally to make the move down into the pelvic

cavity. A large baby, multiple babies, fibroids in your uterus, or a badly placed placenta are all reasons why engagement might take longer. How soon or late the baby's head engages doesn't indicate when you'll go into labor or how quick your labor will be. A baby who engages at 32 weeks is no more likely to make a speedy entry into the world than one who waits until labor has started.



Before engagement Your baby's head hovers freely above your pelvis and she is able to turn and swing around.

After engagement Your baby's head lies within the cavity of your pelvic bones, which can offer relief for your lungs, but you may feel your baby bearing down on your pubic bones.